



NITI Aayog



SECTOR AT A GLANCE 10

Urban: Handwashing with Soap

WASH in India

DRAFT

SECTOR AT A GLANCE 10

URBAN: HANDWASHING WITH SOAP

WASH IN INDIA

The '**Sector-at-a-Glance**' provides an easy-to-read overview and basic understanding of a sector, sub-sector, or thematic area. The facts and insights on the sector are supported by relevant data and best practices from credible government and multilateral sources. The document covers the structure, key trends, opportunities and challenges, government initiatives, and the way forward for the sector.

Suggested Citation:

NITI Aayog (2023). Urban: Handwashing with Soap. NITI Aayog Sector-at-a-Glance Series – WASH in India, 2023-WASH-SAG-10, <link>

Copyright © 2023, NITI Aayog, Government of India

All rights reserved. This draft document and its contents are internal to NITI Aayog. They cannot be reproduced in any manner either in full or parts, thereof. The draft document is subject to further refinements.

All information, ideas, views, opinions, estimates, suggestions, and recommendations (hereinafter 'content') in this draft "portal resource" should neither be understood as professional advice in any manner nor interpreted as policies, objectives, opinions, or suggestions of NITI Aayog. Readers are advised to use their discretion and seek professional advice before taking any action or decision based on these contents. The contents in this portal have been obtained or derived from reliable sources as far as possible. But, NITI Aayog neither represents this information to be accurate nor assumes any liability for any loss, or damages, caused due to any reason whatsoever, towards its usage by a third party. Readers of this document are made aware that the document may be subject to revisions. Any suggestions/input may please be sent to nitiforstates@gov.in.

www.niti.gov.in

Overview

Handwashing with soap is one of the most cost-effective interventions that can help significantly reduce the infectious disease burden, which disproportionately impacts children in urban slums.¹ In recent years, the COVID-19 pandemic has re-iterated that proper hand hygiene is indispensable in preventing and controlling infections.

Adopting urban household-level initiatives and school-level interventions targeting vulnerable communities can improve hand washing with soap and promote hand hygiene practices.

A segment of India's urban population either needs access to handwashing facilities altogether or has access to facilities that lack either soap or water.² In slums, the lack of piped water makes regular handwashing difficult. Infrastructure limitations, high soap costs, and lack of awareness perpetuate poor hand hygiene, contributing to poor health outcomes, such as high diarrheal disease rates among slum children.³

Given these opportunities and challenges, enhancing access to handwashing facilities and promoting better knowledge and practices for the maintenance of proper hand hygiene are the major policy focus areas. Several ongoing and recent central government initiatives, including but not limited to the Swachh Bharat Mission Urban and Kayakalp initiative focus on developing hygiene infrastructure, ensuring regular water supply, and designing innovative methods for behavioural change. These efforts, along with several state- and local-level policies and initiatives, seek to promote a culture of universal handwashing with soap.

This note presents some key statistics and trends, challenges, and opportunities, as well as some ideas for the way forward to improve rates of handwashing with soap in India.

Figure 1: Key urban hand washing statistics

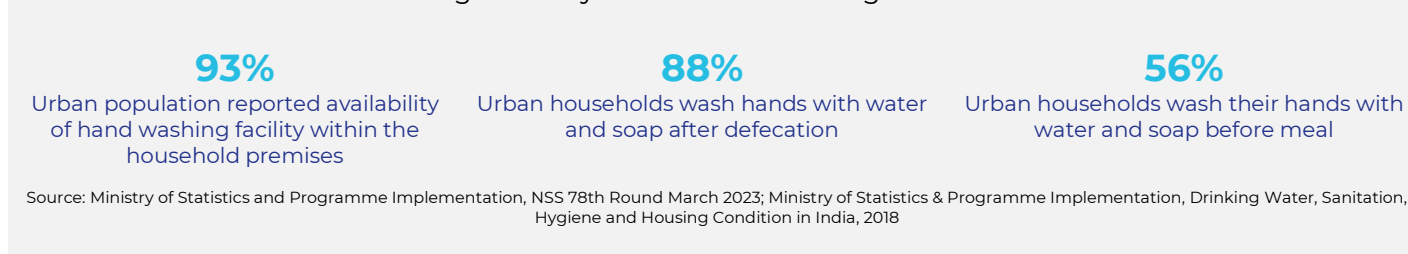
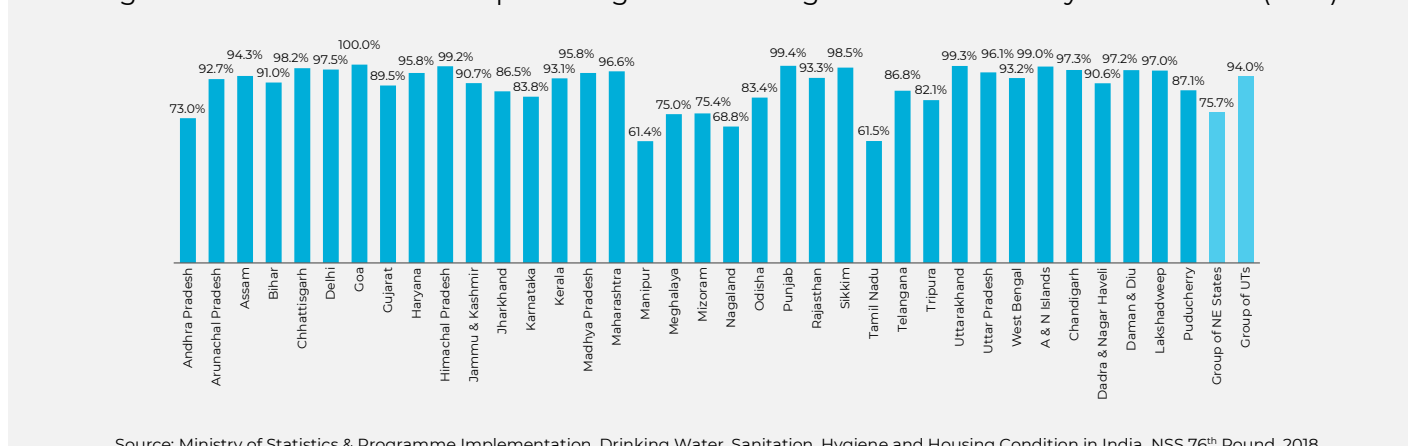


Figure 2: Share of households practising handwashing after defecation by state and UT (2018)



¹ United Nations Children's Fund and World Health Organization, State of the World's Hand Hygiene: A global call to action to make hand hygiene a priority in policy and practice, UNICEF, New York, 2021

² CBGA, IRC and UNICEF, Commitments towards hand hygiene in India: A National level analysis, June 2022

³ United Nations Children's Fund and World Health Organization, State of the World's Hand Hygiene: A global call to action to make hand hygiene a priority in policy and practice, UNICEF, New York, 2021

Opportunities and challenges

Opportunities

This section highlights the outcomes policymakers can achieve by adopting effective hand hygiene practices in urban regions.



Improvement in child health:

Handwashing has strong links to health, particularly in public or institutional settings. Thus, in the context of schools, handwashing facilities with soap and water are considered to be basic hygiene services.⁴ The simple act of washing hands with soap before eating the school mid-day meal assists in breaking disease transmission routes. Moreover, school is an ideal setting for teaching good hygiene behaviour. Studies show that when hand washing becomes part of a child's daily routine, the health benefits are evident and long-lasting.⁵

Challenges

This section highlights some of the major challenges and constraints facing hand hygiene practices in urban regions of India. Efforts to resolve such challenges will ensure greater access to handwashing facilities, increased awareness, and instilling of handwashing practices in daily life.



Limited handwashing facilities:

The urban poor live in crowded, densely populated settlements with inadequate access to safe drinking water and sanitation facilities and less attention to personal hygiene.⁶ Approximately 7% of the urban population either lacks access to handwashing facilities altogether or has access to facilities that lack either soap or water.⁷ Furthermore, accessibility issues such as the height of handwashing stations for children pose additional challenges.



Inadequate knowledge and action towards hygiene maintenance:

In urban India, ~10% of households rely on water to wash their hands after defecation.⁸ Moreover, even where knowledge exists, it does not always translate into action for maintaining hand hygiene. For example, while handwashing with soap may rise during epidemics due to health fears and awareness campaigns, these habits often decline afterwards, revealing a gap between knowledge and action.⁹



Limited sustainability of handwashing-linked behaviour:

Policies and programs relating to this include educational campaigns and IEC programs with targeted messaging for children and their parents, the distribution of hand hygiene products and handwashing stations, and civil society partnerships to mobilize community action.¹⁰ While several government programs and campaigns exist to promote handwashing, there is potential to increase the extent of handwashing practices and knowledge across households and schools to ensure sustained behaviour change.

⁴ UNICEF, Drinking water, sanitation and hygiene in schools: Global baseline report 2018, 2018;

⁵ GoI, Swachh Bharat Swachh Vidyalaya, accessed December 2023

⁶ United Nations Children's Fund and World Health Organization, State of the World's Hand Hygiene: A global call to action to make hand hygiene a priority in policy and practice, UNICEF, New York, 2021

⁷ CBGA, IRC and UNICEF, Commitments towards hand hygiene in India: A National level analysis, June 2022

⁸ Ministry of Jal Shakti, National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey (NARSS), 2019-2020

⁹ WHO, UNICEF, State of the World's Hand Hygiene, 2021

¹⁰ UNICEF India, India WASH Thematic Report, 2018

Institutional framework and policy landscape –

Key ministries and departments

This section highlights the major central government bodies and national-level institutions that oversee urban handwashing practices.



Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs:

The Ministry is concerned with matters related to urban development and aims to tackle the various challenges that arise in the wake of rapid urbanisation in India. This includes themes around housing, poverty, unemployment, development of health, sanitation, and education infrastructure, and so on.¹¹ Thus, handwashing facilities and related initiatives also fall under its ambit.



Ministry of Health and Family Welfare:

The Ministry which operates through its two departments- the Department of Health & Family Welfare and the Department of Health Research, aims to ensure the availability of quality healthcare on an equitable, accessible and affordable basis across India.¹² Issues related to improving handwashing practices with soap in urban India also fall under its ambit.

Major policies and programs

This section highlights existing policies related to urban hand hygiene practices and their most prominent features. A more comprehensive list of policies is provided in the policy repository of the NITI for States platform.



Swachh Bharat Mission Urban (SBM-U):

Under Phase II of SBM-U, including *Swachhata* as part of the school curriculum and awareness generation in schools is a crucial component and delivers critical sanitation and hygiene messages.¹³

A noteworthy campaign under the Swachh Bharat mission is the **Swachh Bharat Swachh Vidyalaya initiative**. This national campaign aims to develop and support appropriate health and hygiene behaviours among students by ensuring every school in India has functioning and well-maintained water, sanitation, and hygiene facilities.¹⁴



National Urban Health Mission:

The National Urban Health Mission integrates hygiene education and infrastructure for handwashing in schools, anganwadis, and community spaces.¹⁵



Kayakalp initiative:

The scheme aims to promote cleanliness, hygiene and infection control in public healthcare facilities, through incentives and recognition of facilities that show good performance in adhering to standard protocols of cleanliness and infection control. Guidelines include details on hand hygiene practices that should be followed by healthcare workers.¹⁶

¹¹ Lok Sabha Secretariat, Background Note on "Housing and Urban Affairs", 2021

¹² Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Vision, Mission and Objective Statement of MoHFW, 2019

¹³ MoHUA, Swachh Bharat Mission - Urban Guidelines, 2021

¹⁴ Ministry of Education, Swachh Bharat Swachh Vidyalaya, accessed July 2023

¹⁵ Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, National Health Mission, accessed July 2023

¹⁶ Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Guidelines for the implementation of the Kayakalp initiative, accessed August 2023

Way forward

Handwashing with soap is a critical public health intervention that can provide significant benefits with very low marginal costs. Though progress has been made in India with the provision of handwashing stations and a significant focus on behaviour change, more is needed to ensure universal adoption of this behaviour.

Some ideas that can drive progress are:

 Enhancing monitoring of handwashing behaviour	Greater investments are necessary to increase the monitoring of handwashing behaviours at a granular level and plan both infrastructural and behavioural interventions based on such data and observations. Innovative methods to enable data can be enabled such as the use of mobile phones for reporting the status of handwashing stations, as well as Internet-of-Things and SMS-based data capturing systems that have previously been used in Indian cities to monitor water supply.
 Adopting a scientific behavioural lens	Historically, handwashing has been approached as a communication problem and IEC materials and even some gamified practices have been deployed at scale. However, there might be merit in exploring a wider range of behavioural levers – such as choice architecture or even the physical design and placement of handwashing stations. Additionally, incorporating adjustments for height and other biases can enhance the usability of handwashing stations.
 Ensuring adequate water and soap supply	Schools and communities should always have access to soap and running water at handwashing facilities. Government agencies can explore collaborations with CSR, domestic philanthropies, and other development partners to ensure this.

Recommended readings

CBGA, IRC and UNICEF. (2022). *Commitments towards hand hygiene in India: A National level analysis*
<https://www.cbgaindia.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/09/commitments-towards-hand-hygiene-in-india-a-national-level-analysis.pdf>

Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs. (2022). *National Behaviour Change Communication Framework for Garbage Free Cities*
<https://sbmurban.org/storage/app/media/national-behaviour-change-communication-framework.pdf>

WHO, UNICEF. (2021). *State of the World's Hand Hygiene*
<https://www.unicef.org/media/108356/file/State%20of%20the%20World%E2%80%99s%20Hand%20Hygiene.pdf>

Ministry of Statistics & Programme Implementation. (2018). *Drinking Water, Sanitation, Hygiene and Housing Condition in India*
https://www.mospi.gov.in/sites/default/files/publication_reports/Report_584_final_0.pdf



सत्यमेव जयते

NITI Aayog

www.niti.gov.in